at all, because I saw it as one of several such badges, to be donned or taken off according to my convenience. My caste identity was relevant to family holidays in my parents' ancestral villages, but irrelevant to my cosmopolitan schooling, and my parents never mentioned (or asked) the caste or religion of any schoolmate who came home to play with me or attend my birthday parties. I grew up ignorant of caste, married outside my caste, and brought up two children to be utterly indifferent to caste, indeed largely unconscious of it. Until my fifties, when I entered the caste-ridden world of Indian politics, it remained that way. Even then I deliberately abstained from finding out the caste of anyone I met or worked with; I hired a cook without asking his caste (the same with my remaining domestic staff) and have entertained all manner of people in my home without the thought of caste affinity even crossing my mind.

One of the key identities in India is, inescapably, caste. As has been noted, to some, it's an instrument of political mobilisation; as the political ascendancy in parts of north India has repeatedly demonstrated, when many Indians cast their vote, they vote their caste. English-speaking urban Indians may scorn such behaviour even while accepting it as part of political reality. After all, none of us would object if a Dalit leader advertised her pride in being a Dalit, or called for Dalit solidarity. Yet my obliviousness to caste is itself a confession of privilege; no Dalit, my Dalit friends tell me, can afford to be oblivious of caste. Much of the outrage at caste is, of course, when it's not a member of an oppressed community celebrating its achievements, but members of one of the so-called 'upper castes', someone at the top of the heap, celebrating their privileges, power and prominence.

Caste won't disappear from the landscape of Hinduism: too many political and administrative benefits (and disadvantages) derive from one's caste affiliation for that to happen, not to mention that for many Indians, it is still part of their lived reality, even though it doesn't pack the same punch it once used to. If it becomes more and more one of many interchangeable, mutable forms of identity—one fraternity of many that an Indian can lay claim to—it may cease to matter so much. The majority of Hindus aren't there yet, unfortunately. And politics may not let them get there either. In recent years we have witnessed the